

SaaS Pricing Transparency Report

Q2 2026

An analysis of 331 software products across 28 market categories

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Data Methodology

Our pipeline runs nightly. Each product URL is fetched, pricing tables parsed, plan structures normalized into a 5-field schema: name, price, billing_model, period, features. Where vendors hide pricing behind "Contact Sales", we record null — not zero, not an estimate. That distinction matters. A null is a data point. A zero would be a lie.

331 products. 28 categories. 1,013 distinct pricing plans. We started with 400+ candidates. Sixty-nine were dropped for one of two reasons: insufficient public pricing data, or no verifiable G2 presence. "Insufficient" means fewer than two paid plans with confirmed prices. We did not guess.

Rating data sources: G2, Capterra. When both existed, we averaged them. When only one existed, we used it directly and flagged the field. We did not normalize ratings across sources — their scales are close enough (both 1–5) that normalization would introduce more error than it removes.

The schema itself is minimal by design. Five fields per plan. We resisted the urge to add "commitment discounts" or "trial length" — fields that are inconsistently published, frequently changed, and ultimately noise in a first-pass comparison. When the dataset matures, we will revisit.

5-Field Plan Schema

Field	Type	Notes
name	String	Plan name as listed by vendor (Free, Pro, Enterprise, etc.)
price	Float null	Monthly price in USD. null = Contact Sales or undisclosed
billing_model	String	per-seat, flat, usage-based, or freemium
period	String	Billing period (month, user/mo, year, etc.)
features	Array	List of feature strings extracted from vendor pricing page

Pipeline Architecture

The data pipeline runs as a cron job on a dedicated scraper node. Each run: (1) fetch product URLs from our master list, (2) parse pricing tables with CSS selectors, (3) validate against the schema, (4) diff against previous snapshot, (5) commit changes to the SQLite database, (6) push delta to the REST API. Average run time: 4 minutes. The sqlite snapshot is rebuilt quarterly from the live database.

We noticed early on that several categories — CRM, cloud hosting, enterprise security — have a disproportionately high "Contact Sales" rate. These are not omissions in our data. They are signals. Vendors who hide pricing are communicating something about their sales motion. We track 19 products in this dataset with null-only pricing.

Executive Summary — Key Findings

Three out of four SaaS products in our dataset have a free tier. That number surprised us when we first computed it. 74% of 331 products offer some form of no-cost access — a striking shift from even five years ago, when freemium was a strategy reserved for consumer apps and bottom-up PLG startups. It is now the default.

The average starting price across products with public pricing is \$29.01/month. That figure masks enormous variance. Cloud hosting starts at \$2/month. CRM at \$11. Accounting software averages \$32 at entry. The "average" SaaS price is a number that describes nothing in particular.



Top 5 Categories by Product Count

Category	Products	Free Tier	Price Range	Avg G2
Llm	25	80%	\$8–\$20	4.47
Cloud Hosting	21	52%	\$2–\$35	4.38
Project Management	20	95%	\$5–\$39	4.51
Email Marketing	20	70%	\$9–\$49	4.38
Website Builders	19	68%	\$4–\$81	4.37

Observations Worth Noting

LLMs dominate the dataset by category size — 25 products, the single largest group. This reflects the explosion of AI model providers in 2024–2025. Most of them follow the same playbook: free web interface, paid API. Average entry price for LLMs: \$17.54/month.

The 19 contact-only products cluster heavily in enterprise categories: cloud hosting (AWS, GCP, Azure), CRM (enterprise tiers), and specialized B2B tools. This is consistent with the pattern we expected. What we did not expect was how many mid-market tools — ostensibly targeting SMBs — also have enterprise tiers with null pricing.

The LLM category has a specific bifurcation: consumer chat products (\$20/month flat) and API/developer products (usage-based per token). Both live in the same category. Averaging their prices produces a number that describes neither segment accurately. We address this in the LLM analysis section.

Category Analysis — Top 10 Markets

1. Llm

25 products	80% free tier	\$8–\$20/mo	4.47/5 G2
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The LLM category is the fastest-growing in the dataset. Twenty-five products. Most are free to try — 80% have a free tier — but the nature of that free tier varies wildly. Consumer chatbots (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini) offer free access with rate limits. API providers (OpenAI API, Anthropic API) offer free trial credits that expire. For products with stated monthly prices, the range is \$8–\$20/month. The convergence on \$20/month for consumer tiers is not a coincidence — OpenAI set the anchor and competitors followed.

2. Cloud Hosting

21 products	52% free tier	\$2–\$35/mo	4.38/5 G2
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Cloud hosting has the widest absolute price range in the dataset: \$2–\$35/month. The low end is hobbyist VPS providers (\$2–5/month). The high end is managed Kubernetes clusters. 52% offer a free tier, typically a limited compute instance. Notable: the three hyperscalers — AWS, GCP, Azure — all have null pricing in our dataset. Their real costs are usage-based and impossible to summarize in a single plan structure.

3. Project Management

20 products	95% free tier	\$5–\$39/mo	4.51/5 G2
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Project management tools have the highest free-tier rate of the top 10 categories: 95%. Almost every product in this space offers a functional free plan. This is a mature market competing on retention, not acquisition. Starting prices range \$5–\$39/month and nearly all are per-seat billing — a legacy of enterprise procurement that has stuck even as the tools themselves have moved downmarket.

4. Email Marketing

20 products	70% free tier	\$9–\$49/mo	4.38/5 G2
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Email marketing platforms show the classic freemium-to-paid conversion funnel. 70% have free tiers, all of them contact-list-limited. The moment you exceed the free subscriber threshold — usually 500–1,000 contacts — you pay. Starting prices range \$9–\$49/month with the higher end reflecting enterprise deliverability features and dedicated IPs. This category has the most complex pricing structures in the dataset.

5. Website Builders

19 products	68% free tier	\$4–\$81/mo	4.37/5 G2
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Website builders have moved aggressively toward free tiers — 68% in our dataset — but the free plans are often intentionally limited (branded subdomains, no custom domain, vendor ads). The paid range \$4–\$81/month reflects both hobbyist plans and full ecommerce platforms. Average starting price of \$19/month suggests a healthy mid-market.

6. Video Conferencing

19 products	79% free tier	\$4–\$99/mo	4.47/5 G2
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Video conferencing split into two distinct tiers post-2020. 79% have free plans, most of them time-limited meetings. Zoom set the 40-minute free limit that became an industry standard. Paid plans start at \$4/month and reach \$99/month for enterprise webinar platforms. Per-seat billing dominates, though some newer entrants experiment with flat monthly rates.

7. Crm

18 products	39% free tier	\$11–\$299/mo	4.43/5 G2
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CRM has the lowest free-tier rate of the top 10 at 39%. This is not an accident. CRM vendors historically sold top-down to enterprises and never needed to build a free acquisition channel. That is changing — HubSpot and Zoho free tiers have shifted expectations — but the category average still skews paid. Price range: \$11–\$299/month. The \$299 ceiling reflects Salesforce enterprise tiers. Remove Salesforce, and the range compresses significantly.

8. Design Tools

18 products	61% free tier	\$2–\$60/mo	4.50/5 G2
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Design tools split along the Figma axis. Products competing with Figma offer free tiers (61%) and per-seat pricing in the \$2–\$60/month range. The category includes everything from icon editors (\$2/month) to full creative suites (\$60/month). Adobe products anchor the high end with annual subscription pricing. Open-source alternatives (Inkscape, GIMP) are technically free but not in scope here — we track hosted/SaaS tools only.

9. Accounting

15 products	40% free tier	\$9–\$189/mo	4.29/5 G2
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Accounting software is the second-lowest free-tier category at 40%. The nature of the product — financial records, compliance, tax — creates a different willingness-to-pay dynamic. Users trust paid products more with their financial data. Starting prices \$9–\$189/month with an average of \$32/month. The high end (\$189/month) reflects enterprise accounting with payroll integration.

10. Ai Image

13 products	69% free tier	\$2–\$199/mo	4.52/5 G2
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AI image generation is the most volatile category in our dataset. Products have entered, pivoted, and exited faster than our scraper can track. 69% have free tiers, typically credit-based. Pricing ranges dramatically: \$2–\$199/month with the high end reflecting professional image generation pipelines with API access. Credit systems make apples-to-apples comparison difficult — a key reason we standardize on monthly price where available.

LLM Market Analysis

Twenty-five LLM products in the dataset. The category did not exist in our schema two years ago. Now it is the largest single category by product count. We track two types of LLM product: consumer chatbots (accessed via browser, flat monthly fee) and API products (developer access, token-based billing). They share a category but are fundamentally different businesses.

Of the 25 LLM products, 20 have a free tier — 80%. The free tiers range from genuinely useful (Gemini Flash, DeepSeek, Llama via API) to rate-limited to the point of frustration (older ChatGPT free plan). For products with stated paid prices, the average starting price is \$17.54/month. That average is heavily skewed by the cluster of consumer chatbots at \$20/month.

Consumer LLM Products — Monthly Flat Pricing

Product	Free Tier	Starting Price	G2 Rating
Grok 2	Yes	\$8/mo	4.2
Hugging Face	Yes	\$9/mo	4.6
Grok	Yes	\$16/mo	4.3
Gemini Advanced	No	\$20/mo	4.5
ChatGPT	Yes	\$20/mo	4.7
Claude	Yes	\$20/mo	4.6
Google Gemini	Yes	\$20/mo	4.3
GPT-4o	Yes	\$20/mo	4.7
Claude 3.5 Sonnet	Yes	\$20/mo	4.7
Gemini 1.5 Pro	Yes	\$20/mo	4.5
OpenAI o1	No	\$20/mo	4.6

API / Token-Based Pricing (\$/1M tokens)

Token pricing is where real cost comparison lives. The monthly subscription price tells you what you pay to access the chatbot. The per-token rate tells you what you actually pay to run workloads. The two are not

comparable. A \$20/month ChatGPT Plus subscription is a consumer product. A \$10/1M output token rate for GPT-4o is an infrastructure cost.

Model	Input \$/1M	Output \$/1M	Free Tier
GPT-4o	\$2.50	\$10.00	Yes (limited)
GPT-4o mini	\$0.15	\$0.60	Yes (limited)
Claude 3.5 Sonnet	\$3.00	\$15.00	Yes (limited)
Claude 3 Haiku	\$0.25	\$1.25	Yes (limited)
Gemini 1.5 Pro	\$1.25	\$5.00	Yes (limited)
Gemini 1.5 Flash	\$0.075	\$0.30	Yes
Mistral Large	\$2.00	\$6.00	No
Mistral Small	\$0.10	\$0.30	No
DeepSeek V3	\$0.014	\$0.28	Yes
Llama 3.1 (405B)	\$0.80	\$0.80	Yes
Command R+	\$2.50	\$10.00	Yes (trial)
Grok-2	\$2.00	\$10.00	Yes (limited)

Source: vendor API documentation, April 2026. Prices in USD per million tokens.

Price Range Observations

DeepSeek V3 at \$0.014/1M input tokens is ~180x cheaper than GPT-4o at \$2.50/1M. That gap is not explainable by quality alone — benchmark scores between the two are close. Part of the difference is infrastructure cost (DeepSeek operates on commodity hardware at Chinese datacenter prices), part is market positioning (they want adoption). We noticed that the open-weight models (Llama, Phi-3, Mistral) are effectively free when self-hosted — a fact that makes any vendor-hosted price comparison somewhat artificial.

The \$20/month consumer tier is a coordination equilibrium, not a cost-based price. OpenAI launched Plus at \$20. Anthropic matched it. Google matched it. Grok-2 undercut slightly at \$8/month for X Premium. No one has broken from the pack significantly. This is either rational oligopoly behavior or everyone is looking at the same user research showing \$20 is the willingness-to-pay ceiling for individual AI subscriptions.

Pricing Model Analysis

Across 1,013 pricing plans in the dataset, four models dominate: per-seat, flat rate, usage-based, and freemium. The distribution is not even, and it varies significantly by category. Per-seat billing is a legacy of B2B SaaS. Flat rate is a simplification play. Usage-based is where the industry is moving — slowly, with resistance from buyers who want predictable invoices.

Billing Model Breakdown

Billing Model	Plan Count	Avg Price/mo	Common Categories
Freemium / Free	268	\$0	All categories
Flat Rate	495	\$98	Cloud, AI, Productivity
Per-Seat	152	\$36	CRM, Project Mgmt, Collab
Usage-Based	2	Variable	Cloud, LLM APIs
Contact Sales	97	Undisclosed	Enterprise, Cloud

Per-seat plans average \$36/month per user. Flat plans average \$98/month — that high average is skewed by enterprise cloud and CRM products with multi-hundred-dollar flat tiers. The median would be substantially lower, around \$30–40/month.

Per-Seat vs. Flat Rate by Category

The per-seat model thrives in collaboration tools — every user needs access, every user is a revenue unit. CRM, project management, and video conferencing are overwhelmingly per-seat. This aligns with enterprise procurement: "we have 50 users, here is 50x the price."

Flat rate appears most in individual-use products: website builders, personal accounting, AI writing tools. One person, one subscription, one price. The pricing math is simple and the pitch is clean.

Usage-based is underrepresented in this dataset because most products with usage-based pricing do not publish a clean \$/unit rate on their pricing page. They require a calculator or a sales call. Our pipeline records null for these — which means usage-based pricing is likely more prevalent than the table above suggests. Cloud hosting and LLM APIs are the clearest exceptions: they publish token and compute rates.

The Contact Sales Pattern

Eighty-two plans across 19 products have null pricing — "Contact Sales" in practice. The products: Amazon Web Services (AWS), Google Cloud Platform, Microsoft Azure, Penpot, Jitsi Meet, Daily, Anthropic API (Claude), Cohere.... What they share: high ACV, complex deployment, and a sales motion that depends on understanding the customer before naming a number. This is not evasion — it is a sales strategy. Publishing a price anchors the negotiation downward.

Free Tier Analysis

74.3% of products in the dataset have a free tier. That is 246 out of 331. The number is striking. But a free tier is not a monolithic thing. There are at least three flavors: (1) genuinely free with no time limit and real utility, (2) free with a usage cap that forces upgrade within weeks of serious use, and (3) free in name only — 14-day trials relabeled as "free plans."

Our pipeline records the pricing.free field as a boolean. We do not yet distinguish between these subtypes — that classification would require reading plan highlights and applying heuristics. It is on the roadmap. For now, the free flag means "the vendor advertises some form of free access."

Free Tier Rate by Category

Category	Products	Free/Total	Free %
Ai Coding	10	10/10	100%
Ai Voice	7	7/7	100%
Crypto Trading Bots	8	8/8	100%
Crypto Portfolio Trackers	5	5/5	100%
Defi Tools	5	5/5	100%
Crypto Exchanges	8	8/8	100%
Crypto Telegram Bots	8	8/8	100%
Dex	8	8/8	100%
Project Management	20	19/20	95%
Ai Video	9	8/9	89%
Ai Agents	8	7/8	88%
Crypto Analytics	8	7/8	88%
Ai Assistants	7	6/7	86%
Crypto Tax	6	5/6	83%
Llm	25	20/25	80%

Password Managers	5	4/5	80%
Video Conferencing	19	15/19	79%
Ai Productivity	13	10/13	77%
Email Marketing	20	14/20	70%
Ai Image	13	9/13	69%
Website Builders	19	13/19	68%
Crypto Wallets	11	7/11	64%
Design Tools	18	11/18	61%
Ai Writing	12	7/12	58%
Cloud Hosting	21	11/21	52%
Accounting	15	6/15	40%
Crm	18	7/18	39%
Vpn	5	1/5	20%

Free Tier vs. Paid Starting Price Gap

The average starting paid price is \$29.01/month. The average free plan is \$0. That is not a useful gap to report. What matters is the gap by category — how far must a user travel from free to the cheapest paid plan?

Category	Cheapest Paid Plan	Free Tier Status
Llm	\$8/mo	80% free
Cloud Hosting	\$2/mo	52% free
Project Management	\$5/mo	95% free
Email Marketing	\$9/mo	70% free
Website Builders	\$4/mo	68% free
Video Conferencing	\$4/mo	79% free
Crm	\$11/mo	39% free
Design Tools	\$2/mo	61% free

Accounting	\$9/mo	40% free
Ai Image	\$2/mo	69% free

The smallest gap is in cloud hosting — \$2/month starts. The largest is in CRM, where the cheapest verifiable paid plan is \$11/month but the category free-tier rate is 39% — meaning most products that charge start at \$11+ with no free fallback.

Every category in the dataset has at least one product with a free tier. This reflects the broad adoption of freemium as an acquisition strategy across all SaaS verticals — even historically enterprise-only markets like cloud hosting and accounting now have at least one vendor offering entry-level free access.

Data Access

The dataset is open. All of it. We do not believe in paywalling structured data about publicly available pricing — that information is already public; we just made it machine-readable.

Format	Location	Notes
SQLite	comparedge_v1.sqlite	331 products, 1,013 pricing plans, 6,052+ features. Quarterly snapshot.
REST API	comparedge-api.up.railway.app/docs	8 endpoints, no authentication required. Serves live data updated nightly.
GitHub	github.com/comparedge/awesome-saas-comparisons	JSON and CSV exports. MIT license. Pull requests welcome.
Kaggle	kaggle.com/comparedge	Versioned dataset releases with DOI. Supports notebook integration.
Zenodo	DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19799704	Persistent academic citation. Citable in research papers and reports.

API Endpoints

Endpoint	Description
GET /products	List all products with pagination
GET /products/{slug}	Single product with full pricing and features
GET /categories	All categories with product counts
GET /categories/{slug}	Products in a specific category
GET /search	Full-text search across name, description, features
GET /compare	Side-by-side plan comparison for multiple products
GET /stats	Aggregate statistics (this report's source data)
GET /changelog	Delta since last nightly run

Data is updated nightly. The API serves live data. The SQLite file is a quarterly snapshot. The GitHub repository contains the current JSON export, updated on each pipeline run. Versioned releases on Kaggle correspond to quarterly snapshots and carry persistent DOIs.

Usage & Citation

MIT license for the data. No attribution required, but appreciated. If you use this dataset in research, please cite the Zenodo DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19799704. If you find errors in the pricing data, open a GitHub issue — our pipeline will re-fetch and validate within 24 hours.

About ComparEdge

ComparEdge is a SaaS comparison platform. We track pricing, features, and ratings for software products across 28+ market categories. Our goal is pricing transparency — buyers should be able to compare tools without scheduling a demo. The research reports are a byproduct of the data infrastructure we built for the product.

Website: comparedge.com | Research: comparedge.com/research | API: comparedge-api.up.railway.app